

MATEO

For Mateo Lombard, a second year student at Parsons studying design, conversations about race don't start with identity, they start with honesty. "I think racial authenticity can divide people," he says. "Stereotypes exist for a reason, but they've also been used to separate us for generations."

Mateo first heard about the idea of racial sincerity through anthropologist John Jackson's book *Real Black: Adventures of Racial Sincerity*. "It stuck with me," he says. "Racial sincerity is about being yourself and following your heart. It's not about denying your race, but about not letting it define every single thing you are."

Growing up, that message came from home, not school. "My family always said: be yourself," he recalls. "School never really said anything at all." His awareness of race took root early. At twelve, his family took a trip through the Deep South, visiting civil rights landmarks and the site where Martin Luther King Jr. was shot. "It didn't make me angry," he says. "It made me aware. It made me see how deep everything runs."

When we talk about the media, Mateo's expression sharpens. "We're more divided now than ever," he says. "If it doesn't make money or make the news, it's not being talked about." He believes pop culture plays a big role in shaping how people see Blackness, for better and worse. "Sometimes Black creators feed into it," he says. "We make content that puts us down, for the entertainment of our own people."

The point isn't blame, it's reflection. Mateo believes internal conversations within Black communities are crucial. "It's not about one protest or one leader," he says. "It's about everyone being honest and challenging their own beliefs. That's where change starts."

When asked about systemic racism, his answer came slowly. "It's still here, just hidden," he says. "You see it in jobs, education, healthcare. It's part of capitalism. It's quieter now, more digital, but it's the same control."

For him, the solution isn't complicated. "People get scared to talk about race," he says. "But connection and growth come from discomfort. You don't need to have all the answers, just be real."

says. "That's not identity. Identity is what's under all of that."

As the conversation winds down, he circles back to the same thought that began it. "I think the meaning of life is simplifying things," he says. "And to simplify everything we just talked about"

"Be yourself and follow your heart."

He smiles as he says it, and it feels less like advice and

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